Understanding the Five Daily Prayers

Names, times, and structure — a plain overview

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The five prayers

Muslims pray five obligatory prayers each day: **Fajr** (dawn), **Dhuhr** (midday), **Asr** (afternoon), **Maghrib** (sunset), and **Isha** (night). Their times follow the movement of the sun and shift slightly each day and with the seasons.

Units of prayer

Prayer is made of units called rak'ah (plural rak'at). Each rak'ah includes standing with recitation, bowing, and two prostrations. The obligatory numbers are: Fajr — two rak'at; Dhuhr — four; Asr — four; Maghrib — three; Isha — four. Voluntary prayers may be added before or after some of these.

Preparation

Before praying, a Muslim performs ablution (wudu), a washing of the hands, mouth, nose, face, arms, head, and feet with clean water. Prayer is offered facing the Ka'bah in Mecca, which is why mosques worldwide include a niche (mihrab) marking that direction.

Congregational prayer

Prayers may be offered alone or in congregation, led by an imam. In congregation, worshippers stand in rows and follow the imam's movements. The Friday midday prayer (Jumu'ah) replaces Dhuhr on Fridays and includes a sermon (khutbah).

Purpose

The prayer punctuates the day with acts of remembrance — a rhythm of recitation, bowing, and prostration that Muslims regard as a direct conversation with God. Its five daily appointments are the most visible practice of Islamic life.

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